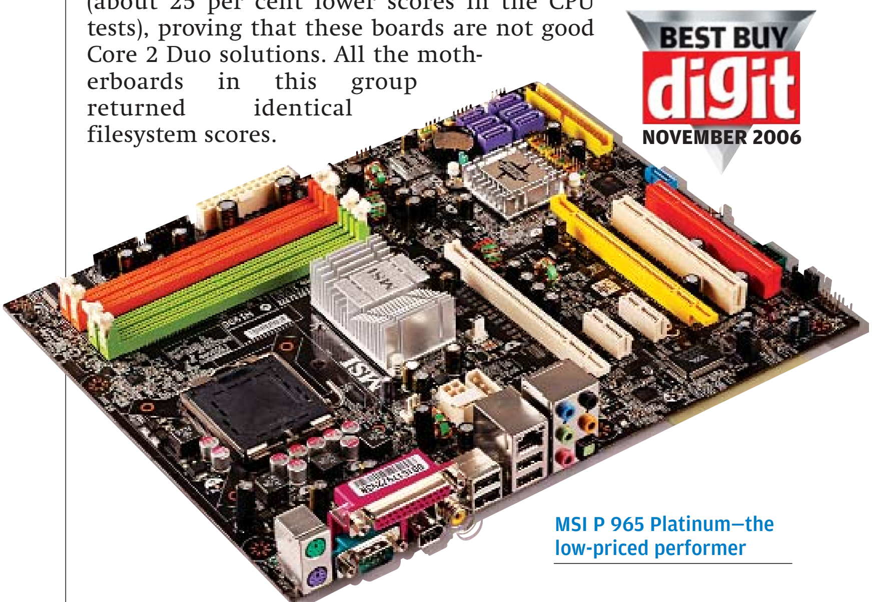
not bottlenecks—by coming up with almost identical scores. The exception—and it seems that there always has to be one—was the Gigabyte GA-965P-DS3, with lower scores than we anticipated. The G965 chipset-based motherboards, the GA-965GM-S2 and GA-965G-DS3, scored badly compared to the competition (about 25 per cent lower scores in the CPU tests), proving that these boards are not good Core 2 Duo solutions. All the motherboards in this group returned identical filesystem scores.



MSI P 965 Platinum—the low-priced performer

Real-World Benchmarks

Our video encoding test, designed to push the boards, brought up hardly any difference in scores. The time taken for P965-based motherboards varied from 70 seconds (GA-965P-DQ6) to 80 seconds (GA-965P-DS3), while the GA-965GM-S2 and GA-965G-DS3 both took 91 seconds. The consistent performance of the P965 chipset here confirms that Intel's optimisation for Core 2 Duos is working well. If it's audio or video editing that you're looking for, look no further than a P965-based board and a Core 2 Duo.

Our Conclusion

Gigabyte's GA-965P-DQ6, the ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP and the MSI P965 Platinum were the top performers in different benchmarks. All three are built sturdily with good subsystems.

With integrated Wi-Fi and dual-Gigabit LAN, the ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP just blows the rest away in terms of features. It also has a great software bundle, including InterVideo Media Launcher.

The MSI P965 Neo-F offers the best value for money, at Rs 6,400. This is much cheaper than the others in the segment, with some G965 chipset-based motherboards costing at least double that. Instead of spending around Rs 12,000 for G965 motherboards, it's better to opt for P965 boards. While the Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6 and the ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP carry the same price tag, the P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP has lot more features than the GA-965P-DQ6. So if you want a feature-rich board with good performance, the ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP is the way to go.

Deciding the winner for this category was difficult. After careful consideration, we awarded the Digit Best Buy Gold to the Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6. The Digit Best Buy Silver goes to the MSI P965 Neo-F, because of decent performance at almost half the price of the others.

945G And 945GZ
Features

This category is the hottest-selling in the market, and is mainly targeted at home and office users where performance is not the only criterion that counts. This category saw six motherboards from ASRock, Gigabyte, and MSI

The Features Myth

A motherboard is one of the most feature-packed amongst all PC components (and we're talking mainly marketable features), so your friendly neighborhood PC vendor being the salesman that he is, will surely try to score here.

Marketable features are not to be mistaken for useful features, which is what we'd like you to be aware of. For example, the classic opening statement "this motherboard has eight USB ports." Sure it does, we agree—but are all those USB ports really needed? How many of them do you plan to use simultaneously? Not more than three, we'd bet! And don't all other boards also come with at least six to eight USB ports? Some ship with 10! The simple fact is that such components are chipset-specific, and motherboard manufacturers can include as many USB ports as the chipset maker allows, so he isn't doing you any favours.

Another such oft-recited feature is 'onboard 7.1 audio'. What good is this going to do for someone planning on 2.1 speakers, or even headphones? A person investing some 10,000 plus rupees on a decent set of 5.1 speakers would be quite able to shell out Rs 4,000 or so for a much higher quality 24-bit sound card (compared to the regular onboard sound solution). On top of all that, there are no 7.1 audio sources to actually utilise all those eight channels of sound.

A lot of motherboards come with a number of PCI-Express x1 slots, too. These aren't a great addition simply because as of now, very few add-on cards sport this interface. A couple of well-laid-out PCI slots and a single PCI express slot (x16) should be enough for most users. Although they do add a certain amount of future-proofing, we think a single x1 slot should be sufficient. What we really want to get across is that this isn't by any means a plus point (having more of such slots), and you shouldn't be paying extra for them!

We intend these examples as eye-openers. A good motherboard is very hard to define, as needs differ greatly across users, but to purchase one on the sole basis of features you'd hardly ever use is pointless. We're not telling you to disregard features, of course—quite the contrary. But you do need to define needs, keeping a little headway for inevitable upgrades that are as natural to PC components as an oil change is to a car!

A much better plan is to check out what future processor upgrades the board's chipset will support, how many drives (whether HD or optical) you can add, number of expansion slots (PCI, PCI-Express, etc.), memory upgradeability, 24-bit onboard sound, presence of FireWire and E-SATA ports, etc.

The point here is to make an informed decision defining your own worth-paying-for features, rather than having a vendor practising a bit of deal-closing on you!